

Feather a raptor's nest — donate to center

By PAT BORDEN GUBBINS

Staff Writer

Winter months are the toughest at the Carolina Raptor Center, especially where power bills are concerned.

The center, which houses and rehabilitates birds of prey, barely gets by from month to month, said director Pat Marcum.

"In fact, we never know, especially this time of year when our income is lower, if we will have money to pay the electricity bill," she said.

One day, Marcum hopes, the center can operate using interest from an endowment. Until then, it depends primarily on donations to pay the monthly bills. During the winter, the electricity bills are around \$450 a month, she said.

"The one for the rehab hospital was over \$300 this month, and the one for the new environmental education building was about half that. So we're talking some major money, just to keep operating," she said.

"One of the big problems we've got is old freezers that were donated. I'm sure they pull a lot of electricity. We never have enough money to buy new freezers. We are forever in need of a walk-in freezer (for food storage)."

The center relies heavily on its 200 or more volunteers, whose efforts include caring for the birds, transporting them and building new cages in any spare time.



T. ORTEGA GAINES/Staff

Needs help: Pat Marcum, director of the Carolina Raptor Center, displays a Swainson's Hawk

from the center. Marcum says the center is in desperate need of financial help.

The cage-building process is slow, because volunteers do the work on weekends and depend on donations to buy the building materials. At the present rate, it would take them about 10 years to build 25 more of the aviaries, Marcum said.

Instead, she is hoping that businesses, clubs, fraternities and

other groups will donate enough money to allow the raptor center to hire someone to build them.

When Marcum became director of the raptor center in 1986, all the cages on the nature trail, except for the golden eagle cage, were made of used chain-link fencing and scrap lumber gathered from local construction sites.

Without properly built aviaries, the birds are vulnerable to the weather and most of their predators.

Labor and materials for each aviary would be about \$3,000, Marcum said. To finance construction of 25 cages, the center will need at least \$75,000 in donations.

Permanent signs with the

donors' name and logo could be placed on the cages for the more than 50,000 annual visitors to see, Marcum said.

Once the new cages are built, one of each species of raptor would be permanently on display. "We've got more than 20 species on the nature trail right now, in either old, inappropriate-type aviaries or in that long condo cage," Marcum said.

The "condo cage" — a series of inter-connected cages — primarily houses birds that are taken out on educational programs. That means occasionally empty cages will greet visitors.

"The peregrine falcon goes out on a lot of programs, so you'll sometimes see the sign, 'peregrine falcon' with nothing in the cage," said Marcum. "We just want to make certain that when people come to the raptor center, they get to see all the species of birds available in the southeastern United States."

Want to help?

To donate, make checks out to the Carolina Raptor Center and mail to the center at P.O. Box 16443, Charlotte, N.C. 28297-6443. Indicate on the check whether you want to donate to "operating expenses" or to "new aviaries." For more information, call the center at 875-6521 weekdays from 9 a.m. to 5 p.m.